

Healthy Priorities

Urban India's Gen Z is beginning to treat health as a daily consideration. This change is driven by access to information, rising lifestyle risks and a desire to avoid future illness

BY NEETU CHANDRA SHARMA

IT OFTEN starts small. Checking the nutrition label on a pack of snacks before tossing it inside the bag. Skipping a second cup of coffee because sleep was short the preceding night. Mentioning stress or sugar levels in a casual conversation.

Across India's cities, young adults are beginning to factor health more directly into everyday decisions. What they eat, what they buy and how they spend are increasingly being influenced by concerns around fitness, energy and long-term wellbeing.

These patterns come through in the BT-PRICE Gen Z Consumption Behaviour Survey conducted by the think tank PRICE for *Business Today*, which covered people aged 18–29 across 12 urban centres, including Delhi, Mumbai, Kolkata and Chennai, along with Tier II cities such as Indore, Jaipur, Kochi and Surat.

These findings suggest that health awareness among young consumers is spreading beyond a few large metros.

THE INFORMATION LOOP

To understand what underpins this behaviour, experts point to the environment young people live in.

"They are surrounded by constant digital information, covering diet, exercise and ideas around appearance, body image and fitness. This exposure shapes how they think about health and influences daily habits, including exercise routines and lifestyle choices," says Dr Samir Parikh, a psychiatrist at Fortis Healthcare and Chairperson of the Fortis National Mental Health Program and Adayu Mindfulness, a mental health treatment centre.

This growing attentiveness comes against a changing health backdrop. Data from the National Family Health Survey-5 by the Union health ministry show that more than one in four Indian adults is overweight or obese, with the prevalence higher in urban areas.

Among the younger population, concerns around weight, stamina and metabolic health are beginning to enter everyday conversations earlier than they used to.

AWARENESS MATTERS

Urban Gen Z is factoring health into daily choices, even when money limits action

Health awareness in Tier-II cities now closely mirrors that of metros

Disposable income still decides how far health intentions go

Young adults link wellbeing to energy, sleep, stress and future illness

Labels, digital access and peer feedback are driving more cautious consumption

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